

All figures sourced from Government of Canada and Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal and provincial statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

## Section 1.5 — The Cohabitation Rule and the Family-Level Operational Reality

The cohabitation rule is the single most consequential operational feature of AISH for recipients who live with another adult. It is also the program feature most working-age Canadians do not know about, because it does not appear in public-facing program summaries and because it operates only after a recipient enters the program. A worker in the cascade traced through Sections 1.1 through 1.4 will encounter the cohabitation rule for the first time at the moment they apply, when the application form requires disclosure of all household members and their incomes. The recipient who succeeds at the application then encounters the rule in a different way: as the mechanism that structures their family life from that point forward.

### What the rule says

Under AISH policy, the income of any adult sharing a household with the recipient may be assessed as part of the household income calculation and used to reduce the recipient's benefit. (*Source: Government of Alberta — AISH benefits and exemption rules; Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped Regulation, Alta Reg 91/2007; Alberta Disability System Breakdown — AISH Evidentiary Report Series, April 2026, Sections 4.6 and 5.*) The policy applies regardless of the nature of the relationship. A married spouse, a common-law partner, a roommate sharing the rent, an adult child temporarily living at home, an elderly parent in a granny suite — all are treated under the same household-income rule. The policy contains some narrow exemptions, notably for paid live-in caregivers and certain documented support arrangements, but these are narrowly defined and require active disclosure and documentation. The default assumption is that any adult sharing the household contributes financially.

The exemption threshold — the amount of cohabiting-partner income that is excluded from the household calculation before reduction begins — is currently \$2,612 per month under AISH. (*Source: Alberta Disability System Breakdown — AISH Evidentiary Report Series, April 2026, Section 3.2; Inclusion Alberta — ADAP Fact Sheet, December 2025.*) Under the post-July-2026 ADAP framework, the exemption is reduced to \$1,500 per month. Above the exemption, the recipient's benefit is reduced by a percentage of the additional household income, with the reduction reaching dollar-for-dollar at higher income levels.

### What the rule does mathematically

The reduction structure is most clearly seen in worked examples drawn from published sources. The campaign's *AISH Evidentiary Report Series, April 2026* documents the following structure for current AISH and the post-July-2026 framework, modelled against publicly available program documentation in the absence of fully published rule tables. (*Source: AISH Evidentiary Report Series, Section 3.3; ADAP analysis by Petit, G., University of Calgary, cited in CBC News, August 21, 2025.*)

Under current AISH, the first \$1,072 of monthly employment income (for a single recipient) is fully exempt. Earnings between \$1,072 and \$2,144 per month are reduced at a 50% rate. Earnings above \$2,144 are reduced at 100%. Under the post-July-2026 AISH structure, the fully exempt amount drops to \$350 per month, and the reduction is modelled at 100% above that figure. Under the ADAP framework, the fully exempt amount is \$700 per month with reduction-rate structure expected to be similar in operational effect.

For a partnered recipient, the spouse-income exemption operates analogously but at the higher initial threshold described above. A spouse earning \$38,000 per year — three thousand one hundred and sixty-seven dollars per month — exceeds the current AISH partner-income exemption of two thousand six

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hundred and twelve by five hundred and fifty-five dollars per month. Above the exemption, the recipient's AISH benefit is reduced at the rate prescribed by the regulation. By the time partner income reaches \$45,000 per year, the AISH benefit is reduced substantially. By the time partner income reaches \$60,000 per year, the AISH benefit is approaching the floor at which it is no longer worth applying for in the first place.

Under the post-July-2026 ADAP framework, the partner-income exemption drops from \$2,612 to \$1,500 per month. A spouse earning \$38,000 per year now exceeds the exemption by \$1,667 per month. The recipient's benefit is reduced from a lower starting point — \$1,740 rather than \$1,940 — by a larger amount, given the lower exemption. The same household income produces a substantially worse outcome under ADAP than it does under current AISH.

### What the rule does to a working spouse

The mathematical structure produces a specific operational reality for the working spouse. A spouse who, prior to the recipient's disability, earned a market wage and was the family's secondary income earner now finds that:

- Working fewer hours reduces household income and is unsustainable, because the recipient's AISH benefit is already inadequate to cover household expenses.
- Working the same hours produces, under the post-July-2026 framework, a smaller net household income than was the case before the change, because the partner-income exemption has been reduced.
- Working more hours — taking a second job, accepting overtime, pursuing promotion — increases gross income but reduces the AISH benefit by a comparable amount, with the marginal household income gain approaching zero at moderate income levels.

This is the structural vise documented in Section 1.1. The spouse cannot work less without losing income the household needs. The spouse cannot work more without losing the AISH benefit at a rate that approaches dollar-for-dollar. The spouse is, in operational reality, financially trapped at a household income level the program rules permit, regardless of what the household actually needs.

The spouse is also, in most cases, the household's primary caregiver. The disabled partner's care needs, depending on the disability, may be substantial and continuous. The financial decision-maker, the household manager, the primary parent for any children in the household, and the person responsible for managing a permanent-crisis-stage marriage is the same spouse. The literature on caregiver burden under disability is consistent across jurisdictions and has been for decades. (*Source: Vitaliano, P.P., et al., "Is caregiving hazardous to one's physical health?" Psychological Bulletin, 2003; Schulz, R., Sherwood, P.R., "Physical and mental health effects of family caregiving," American Journal of Nursing, 2008; Statistics Canada — Portrait of Caregivers, Canadian Survey on Disability, 2017 and 2022.*) Caregiving is associated with increased rates of depression, anxiety, cardiovascular disease, immune dysfunction, and premature mortality in the caregiver. The longer caregiving continues, the more pronounced these effects.

The spouse in this position is not merely under financial pressure. They are under medical, psychological, social, and time-allocation pressure simultaneously. The literature on relationship dissolution under disability reflects this. Marriages in which one partner becomes permanently disabled have higher rates of separation and divorce than the general population, particularly when the disability is acquired in

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mid-adulthood. (Source: Karraker, A., Latham, K., "In Sickness and in Health? Physical Illness as a Risk Factor for Marital Dissolution in Later Life," *Journal of Health and Social Behavior*, 2015; Yorgason, J.B., et al., "Health, disability, and marital quality," *Family Relations*, 2008.) The structural-economic pressure created by the AISH cohabitation rule operates in addition to the medical, psychological, and time-allocation pressures the literature already identifies.

### **What the rule does to non-romantic household arrangements**

The cohabitation rule does not distinguish between romantic and non-romantic cohabitation. (Source: *Alberta Disability System Breakdown — AISH Evidentiary Report Series, April 2026, Section 4.6.*) An AISH recipient who attempts to share a rental unit with a friend, an adult sibling, an aging parent, a co-parenting partner who is not a romantic partner, or a roommate found through a housing-share arrangement triggers a household-income assessment. The other adult's income is potentially counted against the recipient's benefit.

The operational consequence is that the most common cost-sharing strategy used by low-income people in unaffordable housing markets — pooling resources with another adult — is structurally unavailable to AISH recipients. In a province with no rent cap, in a market where average one-bedroom rent ranges from \$1,500 to \$1,900 per month and three-bedroom rent averages above \$2,138 per month, the recipient is required by the rule structure to maintain a single-occupant household at the AISH benefit level — which does not cover the cost of a single-occupant household.

The rule contains a documented exception for paid live-in caregivers under specific arrangements. The exception is narrow. It does not cover practical roommate arrangements. It does not cover co-parenting arrangements. It does not cover multi-generational household arrangements common in Indigenous, immigrant, and low-income communities. The exception covers a specific, formal, documented caregiving relationship and not the broad range of household-sharing arrangements that the rule otherwise reaches.

### **What the rule does to single parents**

Single parents constitute approximately 6.8% of the AISH caseload — roughly 5,426 recipients as of September 2025, almost entirely women. (Source: *Government of Alberta — AISH Caseload Open Data, September 2025; Alberta Disability System Breakdown — AISH Evidentiary Report Series, April 2026, Section 9.1.*) The cohabitation rule operates on this population in a particularly acute way. A single mother on AISH who attempts to share housing with another adult — a friend, a relative, a co-parent of any of her children, a partner — triggers household-income assessment. Her ability to share rent with another adult is structurally constrained. Her ability to enter into a stable adult relationship that progresses to cohabitation — which would, in most non-disabled circumstances, be a stabilizing factor for both her and her children — is structurally penalized.

The campaign's *AISH Evidentiary Report Series* identifies that the ADAP framework was "designed without a gender-disaggregated analysis of its impact." (Source: *AISH Evidentiary Report Series, Section 9.2.*) Programs that ignore gender and caregiving structure in their design consistently produce worse outcomes for women, and the cohabitation rule is one of the clearest examples of the pattern. The rule's effect on single mothers compounds with the post-July-2026 employment-exemption reduction, the housing-cost environment, and the limited availability of accessible community housing for families with children with complex needs.

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### What the rule produces clinically

The structural pressure to live alone has clinical implications for a population whose qualifying conditions include depression, anxiety disorders, post-traumatic stress disorder, complex PTSD, borderline personality disorder, social anxiety disorder, and other mental-health conditions for which social isolation is a documented worsening factor. (Source: Holt-Lunstad, J., Smith, T.B., Layton, J.B., "Social Relationships and Mortality Risk: A Meta-analytic Review," *PLoS Medicine*, 2010; Cacioppo, J.T., Hawkley, L.C., "Social isolation and health, with an emphasis on underlying mechanisms," *Perspectives in Biology and Medicine*, 2003; Public Health Agency of Canada — "Social isolation of seniors," 2017; World Health Organization — *Social isolation and loneliness among older people*, 2021.)

The clinical literature is unambiguous. Social isolation is causally associated with worsened depression, increased anxiety, accelerated cognitive decline, increased cardiovascular disease, increased all-cause mortality, and reduced response to treatment for the underlying conditions that produce isolation as a symptom. A program rule that imposes social isolation as the financially safe default on a population whose qualifying conditions are themselves worsened by isolation is, in operational effect, a rule that worsens the conditions it is supposed to address.

The campaign's *AISH Evidentiary Report Series* documents that the cohabitation rule's clinical impact constitutes engagement of UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Article 19 — the right of persons with disabilities to live independently and be included in the community, with the explicit requirement that persons with disabilities have the opportunity to choose their living arrangements and not be obliged to live in a particular arrangement. (Source: *United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, Article 19; AISH Evidentiary Report Series, Section 4.6.*) Canada ratified the Convention in 2010. Alberta is bound by it. The cohabitation rule, by financially penalizing every shared living arrangement except solitude, does not give recipients the opportunity to choose. It removes the choice and replaces it with a structural incentive toward isolation.

### The lifecycle observation

The cohabitation rule is the working-age expression of a partnership-penalty mechanism that operates across the lifecycle. The same mechanism, in a different program, in different language, with different exemption thresholds and different reduction rates, operates at age 65 through the Guaranteed Income Supplement. Movement Two of this document develops the GIS partnership penalty in detail, with the published Service Canada figures and the Service Canada Form ISP-3040 ("Statement — Spouses or Common-law Partners Living Apart for Reasons Beyond their Control"), which exists in the federal program structure for the same reason this Section identifies in the provincial program structure: because the penalty for partnership is large enough that the program needs an administrative mechanism to determine whether separation is "involuntary" enough to be rewarded.

The cage that this document names operates by the same principle at every stage of life. AISH penalizes cohabitation at the working-age stage. ADAP continues the penalty. Long-term care accommodation calculations apply spousal income tests. GIS reduces the couple-rate to a fraction of two single-rate equivalents. Each program operates the partnership penalty in its own form. None of them is coordinated with any of the others. The recipient navigates each one separately, with no acknowledgment from any of them that the cumulative effect of the same principle applied across forty years is a structural exclusion of the disabled and aging population from family life of any kind.

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Section 1.6 closes Movement One by walking the worker — and the spouse, the children, the household — to age 65, where Movement Two takes over.